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Making a simple jam chuck

1 To make our jam chuck I'm using a piece of tulipwood (*Liriodendron tulipifera*). This timber is perfect for chucking as it is relatively soft with no heavy grain structure, but sycamore (*Acer pseudoplatanus*) and lime (*Tilia vulgaris*) are also ideal. The dimensions for the chuck I'm making here are 100 x 100 x 100mm, but yours will have to suit the size of fruit you're making

2 We start the chuck by roughing down the piece of tulip to a cylinder, I'm using a 20mm spindle roughing gouge with the timber held between centres. When the blank is a true cylinder clean up the tailstock end, using a 10mm bowl gouge with a fingernail grind, using the bevel to rub the surface of the timber and the flute facing roughly 2 o'clock

3 Now the blank can be taken off the lathe and a four-jaw chuck mounted. Use a set of large gripper jaws to hold the cleaned up face of the blank. You now have access to the other face of the tulip blank and can also tidy the area ready for drilling using the bowl gouge

4 We now think about hollowing out the chuck ready for use but before we try and turn, the task is made a lot easier if you drill a hole through the blank. Use a keyless chuck in the tailstock and a 40mm sawtooth – remember sawtooth bits are intended for end grain cutting whereas the Forstner bit is for side grain

5 Cut two-thirds of the way into the blank keeping the hole clear of shaving by retracting the drill bit frequently and, if needed, by adding wax polish as a lubricant. Once this side is drilled to two-thirds, turn the blank over and drill from the other side until the blank has a hole running all the way through it. The speed of the lathe with this size bit is around 600rpm

6 Now that the blank has been drilled through, turning the rest of the chuck out is a much easier task. Start from the inside of the chuck and work outwards, cutting the side grain as you go, with the flute of the gouge facing 10 o'clock. This method is much easier than going straight for the end grain, which you will only do when cutting the taper to the inside. Taper both ends of the chuck to slightly different sizes, meaning different sizes of fruit can be held

7 After the turning is done, both sides can be sanded with a coarse abrasive. You will need to experiment with the taper to see which gives you the best grip – too small a taper then the grip will be tight and you could get the fruit stuck and damage it trying to get it out whereas if the taper is too great the grip will be poor and the fruit may dislodge before intended ●

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